



Glorious past: Mumbai is home to Victoria Terminus, one of its two World Heritage sites, but sees itself only as a business destination



SHASHI K. PAUL

team of architects, interpretation experts, landscapers, art and textile historians, museum specialists, graphic designers, communications and graphics professionals.

Every historic property in the UK has a well-merchandised shop selling innovative products of high quality and many of the products are available online. While the range of products sold at even a prime site such as Taj Mahal would include at the most some ASI publications (and hordes of tacky souvenirs), English Heritage and National Trust products include high quality medieval-inspired jewellery, castle models and DIY kits for children,

puppet sets, princess and knights costumes that generate revenue for each site. The innovative marketing strategies adopted by English Heritage include allowing well-heeled customers to indulge in fine dining at Chiswick House or Eltham Place; host fairy tale weddings at the historic Bolsover Castle and Kenilworth or even book for a corporate conference, historic properties such as Osborne House and Gardens. This is something that would be unheard of in a historic Indian site.

What is a matter of significance, is the need for incentives for all stakeholders. When the ticket sales of a site go back into a larger pool, it does not create a stake for the local site managers to achieve better visitation. If a larger chunk of the revenues generated by Taj Mahal was to be ploughed back towards international standards of visitor facilities, and if there was a better local authority

buy-in into the system, we could perhaps hope for a better visitor experience to our most visited site.

A city's financial revival is accompanied by an urban facelift with huge capital investment in public infrastructure and restoration of city landmarks. This becomes the launchpad for the city's entry into the big league, highlighting its architectural monuments as its icons, a classic case being that of New York in the time of Rudy Giuliani. Paris got a makeover with Baron Haussmann a few hundred years ago, swapping its medieval rat-infested alleys for grand neo-classical avenues, and again more recently when president Francois Mitterand launched the grand schemes of La Defense and the revitalisation of the Louvre.

Unfortunately, we are yet to realise this at a city level and though Mumbai is home to two World Heritage Sites (Elephanta and Victoria Terminus now renamed Chhatrapati Shivaji Terminus), it has not even begun to think of itself as anything but a business destination. While Delhi seems better poised with more listed buildings, urban conservation of precincts and clear conservation guidelines for its urban villages housing many of its historic monuments are still to be legislated.

Though we are beginning to see a trend at privately-owned historic properties getting a makeover, the phenomenon of boutique hotels and the adaptive reuse of Rajasthani forts into heritage hotels, there is a crying need to ensure that these are not just islands of luxury. In order to maintain a balance between modernity and heritage, a regulatory framework is necessary, but more importantly, sound economic strategies and the political will to back that framework. This needs to be supported by documentation,

followed by rules that prescribe the site management policy, zoning rules, visitor facilities and design guidelines for any interventions. This needs to be followed by a monitoring strategy to note the status of management. These, supported by good governance, out-of-the-box thinking and marketing skills can ensure the revival of a nation's tangible and intangible heritage.

The author is executive committee member of the Urban Design Research Institute, Mumbai.

£170 mn

THE MONEY RAISED ANNUALLY BY ENGLISH HERITAGE THROUGH TICKET REVENUE, MUSEUM SHOP SALES, EVENTS AND PUBLIC PATRONAGE.

Making Money

CAMBODIA RELIES ON ITS WORLD HERITAGE SITE OF ANGKOR WAT FOR A BULK OF ITS GDP.